

To: Board of Directors
From: Kristina Howard, Senior Chief; Dr. Jenny Withycombe, Assistant Dir Health & PE
RE: K-12 Health Curriculum Adoption
Date: May, 2026

ITEM FOR INFORMATION

Date of Meeting: May 26, 2026

Title: K-12 Health Curriculum Adoption

Background:
The Health & Physical Education team has completed a rigorous, four-year Comprehensive K-12 Health Education Instructional Materials Adoption. This extended timeline was a deliberate choice, not a circumstantial one. Health education is uniquely dynamic: the science of youth and adolescent health, evolving community needs, and the health behaviors of young people do not stand still, and neither did we. By taking the time necessary to engage deeply with staff, students, families, and community stakeholders, we are confident that the materials we are bringing forward represent the best available resources to support the whole health of Portland Public Schools students.

The recommended curricula align with the latest Oregon Health Education Standards, meet the requirements of Division 22 — the Oregon Department of Education's framework ensuring districts provide quality education in compliance with state law — and reflect Portland Public Schools' instructional priority to adopt High-Quality Instructional Materials across all core subject areas.

This curriculum adoption process is unique in that we have field-tested and are recommending the adoption of instructional materials across five sub-content Health topics:

- Mental and Emotional Health
- Food and Nutrition
- Substance Use Prevention
- Comprehensive Sexuality Education
- Violence Prevention

Unlike other core subject areas, we do not have a comprehensive health textbook to recommend at any grade band. While our AIR committees did meet with vendors such as Goodheart-Wilcox, they did not



recommend them for field testing. Typically, health textbooks do not meet our state's health standards and laws, nor are they flexible enough for us to respond to student data (such as data from the Youth Risk Behavior Survey or the School Health Survey). Instead, we field-tested standards-aligned instructional materials designed and written by various public health organizations (e.g., Advocates for Youth, Stanford's REACH Lab, and Cairn Guidance) that specialize in curriculum for the sub-content areas listed above.

Related Laws, Mandates, and Policies:

In addition to following the PPS Comprehensive Health Education policy (Board Policy 6.40.013-P), as well as aligning curriculum with the latest Oregon Health Education standards (2025), we are responsible for providing instructional materials that support several laws, mandates, and policies, including:

Comprehensive Sexuality Education: OAR 581-022-2050, ORS 336.455
Oregon **requires** medically accurate, age-appropriate sexuality education as part of the health curriculum. Students must receive instruction on human sexuality, healthy relationships, consent, STI/HIV prevention, and responsible decision-making.

Substance Use & Drug Prevention: OAR 581-022-2045
All high school students must receive annual instruction on the effects of alcohol, tobacco, and drugs as part of a comprehensive health education program.

Synthetic Opioid (Fentanyl) Prevention: SB 238
Oregon requires districts to teach synthetic opioid prevention lessons in grades 6–8 and at least once in high school.

Teen Dating Violence Prevention: Healthy Teens Relationship Act ORS 339.366, HB 4077
Schools must provide instruction on teen dating violence, domestic violence prevention, consent, and healthy relationships for students in grades 7-12.

Suicide Prevention Education: Adi's Act OAR 581-022-2510, ORS 339.343, SB 52
School districts must implement a comprehensive suicide prevention plan that includes mental health education, prevention strategies, and intervention supports for students K-12.

Sexual Abuse Prevention Education: Erin's Law OAR 581-022-2050, ORS 336.059, SB 856



Schools must provide at least four instructional sessions per year on sexual abuse prevention for students in Kindergarten through grade 12.

Bullying & Harassment Prevention: OAR 581-022-2310, ORS 339
Districts must educate students on preventing harassment, intimidation, bullying, and cyberbullying and provide guidance on responding to unsafe behavior.

You can find a complete list of laws, policies, and mandates on our PPS Health & PE Website.

Connection to Board Goals:
Health education supports young people to gain age-appropriate knowledge and skills that foster healthy behaviors, empowered decision-making, and a holistic understanding of their role in promoting individual, family, and community safety and well-being. Research shows that when health education is comprehensive, inclusive, skills-based, and scaffolded across grades, it leads to improved school climate, reduced violence, increased individual academic achievement, and long-lasting intergenerational benefits.[1]

The Health and Physical Education (HPE) Team plays a crucial role in supporting the whole child, ensuring that every student in our district has the opportunity to succeed academically, socially, and physically. Aligned with our District Continuous Improvement Plan (DCIP) priorities—increasing attendance, improving literacy, improving math, and supporting 9th-grade success—our curriculum adoption also reflects our district's Health objectives to foster inclusive practices, standards-based teaching, and student well-being. Health Education offers unique opportunities to foster a sense of belonging, agency, and enjoyment in learning, which directly contribute to improved attendance.

Community Engagement:
Over the course of the adoption we have engaged with the community in a variety of ways. One of these initiatives, as an example, was to gather feedback from the community, including students, on ways in which we could create a more culturally-affirming, trauma-informed nutrition curriculum for our students. In addition to incorporating feedback from the 207 students we heard from, we also engaged with community-based organizations to inform the development of new instructional materials.

During the development of our latest Comprehensive Sex Ed materials we surveyed high school students about their experiences with the previous iteration of materials to see ways in which we could

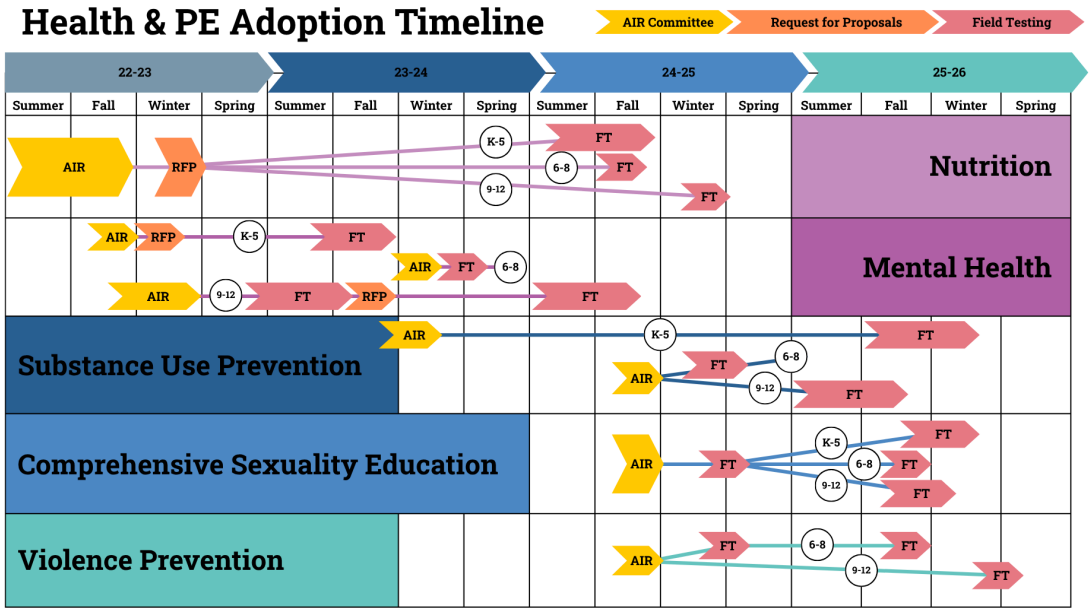
[1] Oregon Health Education Standards, ODE (2023)

be more trauma-informed. We also worked with a small group of youth to review drafts of the new high school CSE lessons and provide feedback. The information we received from both the survey and our youth panel was shared with the curriculum developers to support standards-aligned, trauma-informed revisions to the materials.

This year, the Health & PE Team engaged with community stakeholders in two additional ways: first, we hosted an all-day open house at the Dr. Matthew Prophet Education Center (PEC) that included an evening presentation and listening session. Our team staffed the PEC lobby to provide access to instructional materials, answer questions, and hold space for conversation. Secondly, our team met with members of the Village Table (formerly F.A.C.E.) to provide an update on our adoption process, create space for conversations, answer questions, and share instructional materials to gather community feedback.

Timeline for Implementation & Evaluation:

Our sub-content adoptions were conducted across four years:



Note: We received grant funding to support the procurement of the Mental Health and Nutrition curricula. Our staff supporting this work on AIR committees could not recommend existing curricula, so Cairn Guidance wrote each set of instructional materials for both sub-content areas and piloted them with teachers. This is why there is an extended timeline for those sub-content areas.



Staff Recommendations:

Sub-Content Area	K-5	6-8	9-12
Mental & Emotional Health	Cairn Guidance	Cairn Guidance Signs of Suicide	Cairn Guidance Signs of Suicide
Food, Nutrition, & Physical Activity	Cairn Guidance	Cairn Guidance Let's Eat!	Cairn Guidance
Substance Use Prevention	5th Grade: Stanford REACH	Project ALERT HealthSmart	Stanford REACH: Safety First
Comprehensive Sexuality Education	Advocates for Youth: *Rights, Respect, Responsibility*	ODHS: *My Future-My Choice*	Advocates for Youth: *Rights, Respect, Responsibility*
Violence Prevention	Second Step Adopted in 2023	ODHS: *My Future-My Choice*	Nest Foundation: *You Belong Here*

Recommended for Adoption: Participants approved these instructional materials.

K-5 Substance Use Prevention:

Our 5th-grade field testers recommended Stanford REACH Lab's *You and Me Together, Vape Free,* and *Smart Talk* (related to cannabis-use prevention). Our field testers in grades K-4 implemented lessons from several vendors (e.g., Generation Rx, Ask.Listen.Learn, Operation Prevention) but were concerned about gaps in standards alignment and inconsistencies in language and pedagogical approach from one lesson to the next.

This team recommends issuing a Request for Proposals to solicit vendors to design lessons specifically for this sub-content area.

Note: Please see the link under "Resources" to access the Adoption Decision Forms, which provide more information about the selection and approval process and rationale for each sub-content area.

Fiscal Impact:

Many of the materials we are recommending are available to us at no cost. Please refer to the table below for a cost breakdown of this adoption:



Grade Band	Unit/topic	Vendor / Contract	Estimated Cost
HS	Violence Prevention	NEST	$350,000 (5-year)
MS	Substance Use	ETR	$410,891.78 (5-year)
Subtotal			$760,891.78
Anticipated Design and Development Costs			
MS	Sex Ed and Violence Prevention	ODHS (*My Future-My Choice*)	$175,000 for curriculum development
ES	Comprehensive Sex Ed	Advocates for Youth	$11,700 for Graphic Design to align all K-5 lesson plans to the most recent layout
Subtotal			$186,700.00
Anticipated Professional Learning Costs			
ES	Comprehensive Sex Ed	Advocates for Youth	$59,450.00: Curriculum-aligned grade level learning modules (see proposal)
Subtotal			$59,450.00
TOTAL COST			**$1,007,041.78**

Resources:

- Village Table Presentation